

Law of Proximity

What is it?

People assume that elements placed close to each other are related, even if they are not.

History

Introduced through Gestalt psychology research around **1912**, showing that humans naturally group nearby visual elements to make faster sense of information.

The Psychology Behind It

- Nearby items form mental groups
- Closeness creates perceived relationships
- Brain uses proximity to simplify scanning
- Structure becomes easier to understand visually

Why It Matters

- Helps build stronger visual hierarchy
- Improves scannability
- Can cause crowding issues
- May mislead users if grouping is unclear

How to Apply It

- Use intentional spacing (margins, padding, white space, grid systems)
- Group content using visual cues like color or shape
- Break content into chunks such as accordion flows and step-by-step layouts

Theory in Action

- Amazon groups product info, reviews, and the Add to Cart button closely to reduce decision effort
- Supermarkets place related items like pasta, sauce, and cheese together to make meal decisions easy and intuitive

Final Thought

Proximity guides meaning. Strategic grouping helps users instantly see what's related and reduces confusion in digital and physical experiences.

